

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

A return to grand old days

AT&T's N.Y. headquarters like a 50-story picture frame

On Saturday mornings my small son watches a television cartoon program called "Superheroes."

The Superheroes work out of a building called the Hall of Justice.

If there ever was a place that called for some architectural magnificence, it's surely that Hall of Justice, headquarters for the likes of Superman, Batman and Wonder Woman.

So what do the TV artists make the Hall of Justice look like? Like Union Terminal in Cincinnati. In other words, Art Deco, the style of the Chrysler Building and the World's Fair of '39 and the Radio City Music Hall.

What else can the artists do? Art Deco was the last era in which architects gave the public anything adequate to satisfy our craving for the grand, the truly monumental gesture in architecture.

What this means is that architects today should probably be applauded when they try to learn to be grand and popular again, as Art Deco was grand and popular.

That at least one architect is trying — trying much too hard, probably — hasn't been in question since the morning of March 31. That was the day Philip Johnson's design for a new headquarters for the American Telephone and Telegraph Company was published on the front page of the New York Times.

Reaction in the architectural community was instant and intense. Critics were split. One New York writer said the building had a "silly top," others compared it to a grandfather clock, a 1920s radio cabinet or a piece of Chippendale furniture. Clippings quickly appeared on architectural school bulletin boards.

To understand the reaction, you have to know something about Philip Johnson.

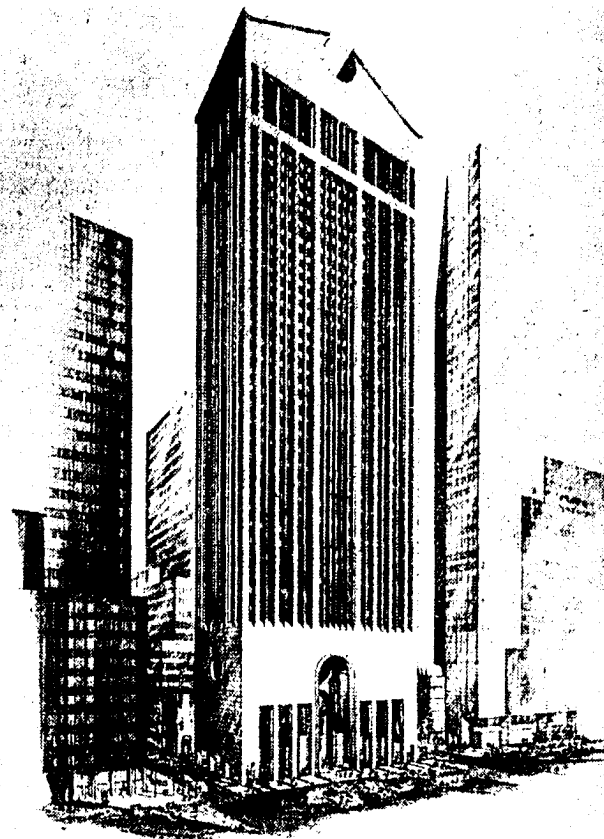
If the AT&T building had been de-

signed by a student as a school project, he would probably get either a snub or a condescending pat. But Philip Johnson is about to be awarded the profession's highest honor, the Gold Medal of the American Institute of Architects, at the AIA's convention in Dallas next week. Long one of America's two favorite establishment architects (with I.M. Pei), he has been notable for switching styles every few years. Buildings such as the addition to the Boston Public Library or New York State Theatre at Lincoln Center are from his plastic-heroic period. In the early 1960s he collaborated with his then-mentor Mies van der Rohe on the ultimate glass-box skyscraper, the Seagram Building in New York.

Earlier Johnson designed, for himself, his famous Glass House in New Canaan, Conn., one of the most publicized buildings of our time. Still earlier, before becoming an architect, he was director of architecture at the Museum of Modern Art in New York, where he and Henry-Russell Hitchcock produced an exhibit and book on "The International Style" (1932) that made European modernism respectable in the United States.

It's against that background of firsts that the new building has to be understood. At a press conference Johnson, who did so much to bring modernism to America, said the building's purpose was to seek an alternative to modernism. He said: "The design shows a striking difference from the usual glass-sheathed, flat-topped boxes of our newer cities. There is more reminiscence, more history."

The building's basic image is that of a 50-story picture frame. The top, which is what most people notice, is in the shape of a broken pediment. The base is a blank wall on heavy columns, behind which is open pedestrian and shopping space. What is "framed" is the 30-odd floors of offices.



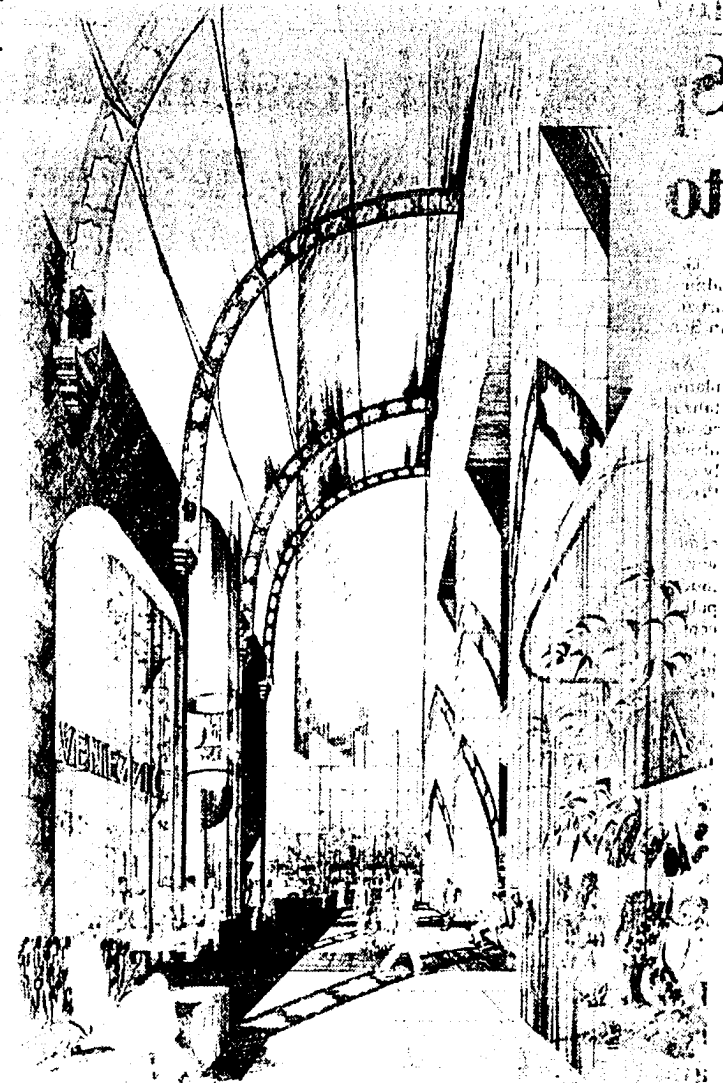
Proposed headquarters in New York for American Telephone and Telegraph has been called everything from a grandfather clock to Chippendale furniture. Architect is

Dividing a building this way into base, shaft and top was a basic idea of early skyscrapers based on imitation of the Greek column. But AT&T doesn't look like those buildings. Closer to the mark are the people who compare it to furniture. Like something you'd see at Barbo's, it's been deliberately "styled," that is to say given an arbitrary shape that has nothing to do with its function but is instead meant to recall some romantic time or place. It's like a "Spanish Provincial" stereo cabinet. Such stylings aren't usually authentic reproductions but merely give you a few de-

tails to establish what they're symbolizing.

Johnson's building is just like that. The top reminds you of the broken pediments of Renaissance structures by such figures as Michelangelo, but instead of Michelangelo's power there is merely a smoothed-out, simple version of the same shape, as flat as a paper cut-out.

What this building reminds you of — deliberately, no doubt — is those pathetic attempts we often see around us to buy gentility on the cheap. The



Philip Johnson, current Gold Medalist of the American Institute of Architects. At ground level, AT&T Building features a "Galleria" connecting two side streets.

plastic shutters on the Georgia motel, never meant to be closed, never even meant to look much like shutters, are really there just to remind you of Tara. As thinly, as sentimentally and cynically as that, the AT&T reminds you that architects once knew how to design in a way that people thought was grand. Just as surely, it shows you that this isn't the way to do it.

Apart from its message, the building is interesting in other ways. That round break in the top of the pediment will gush steam, which will be floodlit at

night, making the world's first public steam sculpture. Sculptor Joan Brigham has been proposing something similar for the fountain in Boston City Hall Plaza.

Behind AT&T, connecting 55th and 56th streets, will be a public "Galleria" opening to shops on one side and the building on the other. It's detailed in a way that's meant to remind you of the famous Galleria in Milan. At its north end it will face another new architectural blockbuster, Edward Larrabee Barnes' IBM headquarters. Who said Manhattan was dying?